Yet, the list of things that sets them apart runs equally long. Their first difference was their upbringing. Iqbal was raised in the household of a poor hat maker in the hinterland of Lahore. His early education took place in Indian mission schools and the Government College in Lahore. Nehru's father, Motilal, had risen to be one of India's most accomplished and wealthy lawyers and sent young Nehru to Harrow, a boarding school in England. While both attended Trinity College in Cambridge in the first decade of the twentieth century, Nehru did so as an undergraduate to read for the natural sciences tripos, entirely aloof from any financial burdens. Iqbal was a non-degree student who had taken leave from his work as an untenured college lecturer in Lahore, funding his stay through a sparse monthly stipend he received from his older brother and leaving his young son and wife behind in Lahore.

On more doctrinal points, Nehru promoted an inclusive nationalism and a democratic future with joint electorates. In contrast, Iqbal squarely focused on Muslim rights and their place in India's political and cultural landscape, which led him to endorse separate electorates and reserved seats for Muslims.[7] Iqbal also received and never returned a knighthood. Even at the height of

anti-British sentiments among Indians, he preferred to be addressed as Sir Muhammad. As president of the Muslim League in 1930, Iqbal also proposed grouping Muslim majority provinces in India's north-west together, an idea that was later spun forward, albeit in very different shape and form, by proponents of the Pakistan movement.

In 1933, during their first brief spat, Iqbal had sharply criticized Nehru in a public statement for ascribing the failure of the Round Table Conferences, where India's constitutional future was discussed, to the conservative political outlook of the Muslim delegation and their lack of nationalism. Partly embracing this criticism, Iqbal retorted that 'if by "nationalism" he [Nehru] means a fusion of the communities in a biological sense, I should personally plead guilty to the charge of anti-nationalism'.[8] In Iqbal's understanding of nationalism, rejecting the fusion of communities into a single nation was not anti-national. Nationalism in India had to be